Chapter 7 · Story

Two teams stop sharing a table.

An original story at the Common Ground repair café.



When “we” takes over · c07s01

A fictional story. A real question about people.

What would you do?

The shared checklist is unfinished. What is a useful first change?

A Agree on owners, deadlines, and needed support.

B Tell everyone their commitment is disappointing.

C Copy more people onto every task.

Suggested answer: A. Agreed owners, deadlines, and support make responsibility clearer and help people coordinate the work.

Identity changes the boundary of “us.”

- **Social identity**: groups help define who we are.
- **In-group favoritism**: favoring “our” side.
- Shared goals can widen the circle.

Who counts as “our team”?

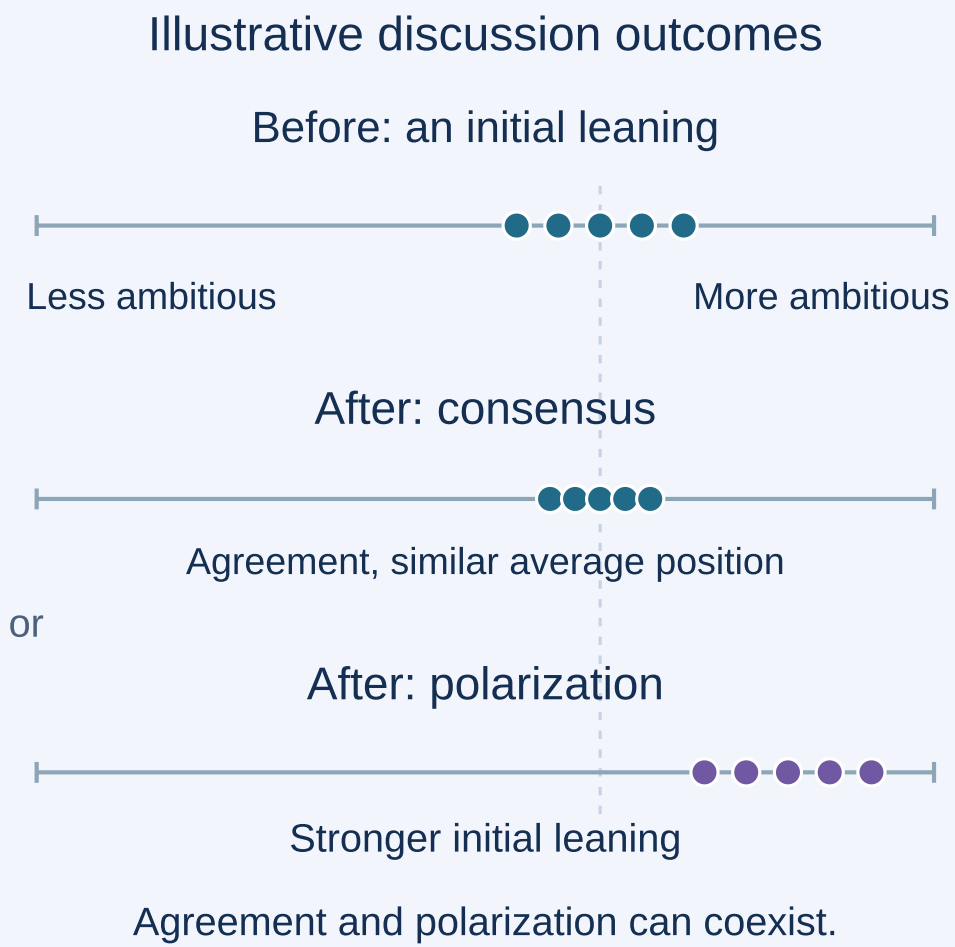
Repair volunteers	Welcome volunteers
	
“Give our team first choice of shifts.” Group membership can shape preference.	Their contribution can be overlooked. Favoritism can create unequal access without explicit hatred.

Check workload, incentives, and decision power.
A shared name alone does not change those.

Group preference can produce unequal treatment.

Groups can amplify—or lose—effort.

- **Group polarization**: discussion can intensify a group’s initial leaning.
- **Social loafing**: individual effort can fall in pooled work.
- **Coordination loss**: real effort is poorly combined.

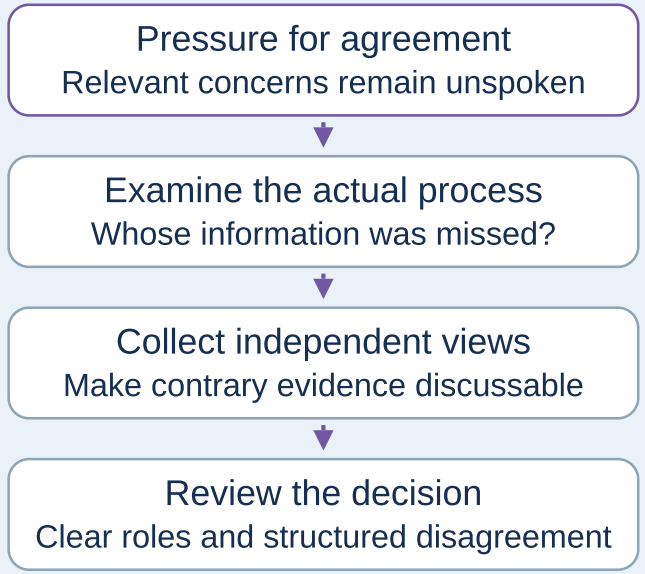


Agreement can form with or without a more extreme leaning.

What can we really conclude?

Groupthink describes cases where pressure for agreement interferes with critical discussion. A poor decision alone does not establish that this process occurred. To review the café’s planning meeting, look at what happened during the discussion. Which concerns were withheld? Which information was repeated or missed? Were roles or incentives unclear? Then choose a change that addresses the process you found. Independent estimates can broaden the evidence. Clear roles can improve coordination. Structured disagreement can make concerns easier to express. These changes help the team investigate the decision without pretending to know every member’s private thoughts.

Agreement can hide unspoken doubts



A poor decision alone does not establish groupthink.

Ask members about their concerns and check which information reached the discussion.

Try the idea somewhere new.

An event budget keeps escalating without checking demand. What helps?

A Ask members to show stronger enthusiasm.

B Gather independent estimates and contrary evidence.

C Open with the chair’s preferred budget.

Suggested answer: B. Independent estimates and contrary evidence give the group information beyond its existing enthusiasm.

Close your notes. Explain it.

> How does polarization differ from consensus?

> How can a willing group still perform poorly?

1. Consensus is agreement. Polarization is movement toward a more extreme position from an initial leaning.

2. A willing group can still lose output through poor sequencing, duplicated work, missing tools, or unclear roles.



Maya, Sam and Leo at the repair café.

Carry one idea into your week.

Choose a shared project you know well. Map each task, its owner, what must happen before it can start, and when progress will be checked. Identify one plausible obstacle and a check that could distinguish it from another explanation before proposing a remedy.

Revisit tomorrow and in a week.
Explain it without notes, then use a different example.



Take the question into a different setting.